The Color of Water

By James McBride

JAMES: **(Pg xvii)** As a boy, I never knew where my mother was from – where she was born, who her parents were. When I asked she'd say, "God made me." When I asked if she was white, she'd say, "I'm light-skinned," and change the subject. She raised 12 black children and sent us all to college and in most cases graduate school. Her children became doctors, professors, chemists, teachers - yet none of us even knew her maiden name until we were grown.

INTRODUCTION

It took James McBride 14 years to unearth his mother's remarkable story – the daughter of an Orthodox Jewish rabbi who married a black man in 1942. In this excerpt, James examines her life, his own childhood in Brooklyn's housing projects, and the force of his mother's love. The Color of Water: A Black Man's Tribute to His White Mother by James McBride

JAMES: **(Pg 21-25)** Answering questions about her personal history did not jibe with Mommy's view of parenting twelve curious, wild, brown-skinned children. She issued orders and her rule was law. Since she refused to divulge details about herself or her past, and because my stepfather was largely unavailable to deal with questions about himself or Ma, what I learned of Mommy's past I learned from my siblings. We traded information on Mommy the way people trade baseball cards, offering bits and pieces fraught with gossip, nonsense, wisdom, and sometimes just plain foolishness.

RICHIE: What does it matter to you? You're adopted anyway.

JAMES: You're lying.

RICHIE: You'll see when Mommy takes you back to your real mother next week. Why do you think she's been so nice to you all week?

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JAMES: Suddenly, it occurred to me that Mommy ***had*** been nice to me all week. But wasn't she nice to me all the time? I couldn't remember, partly because within my confused 8-year-old reasoning was a growing fear that maybe Richie was right. Mommy, after all, did not really look like me. In fact, she didn't look like Richie, or David – or any of her children for that matter. We were all clearly black, of various shades of brown, some light brown, some medium brown, some very light-skinned. And all of us had curly hair. Mommy was, by her own definition, "light-skinned," a statement which I had initially accepted as fact but at some point later decided was not true.

There was something inside me that told me. It was in my blood, you might say. Yet Mommy refused to acknowledge her whiteness. Why she did so was not clear, but even my teachers seemed to know she was white and I wasn't. On open school nights, the question most often asked by my schoolteachers was, "Is James adopted?" which always prompted an outraged response from Mommy.

JAMES: If I'm adopted, you're adopted too.

RICHIE: Nope. Just you, and you're going back to your real mother in jail.

JAMES: I'll run away first.

RICHIE: You can't do that. Mommy will get in trouble if you do that. You don't want to see Ma get in trouble, do you?

JAMES: *(Panic setting in)* But I don't want to go to my real mother. I want to stay here with Ma. . .

RICHIE: You gotta go. I'm sorry, man.

JAMES: This went on until I was in tears. I remember pacing about nervously all day while Richie, knowing he had ruined my life, cackled himself to sleep. That night I law wide awake in bed waiting for Mommy to get home from work at 2 a.m.

MOMMY: *(laughing)* You're not adopted.

JAMES: So you're my real mother?

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MOMMY: Of course I am. *(big kiss)* You want some coffee cake?

JAMES: Enough said . . . In 1966, when I was 9, black power had permeated every element of my neighborhood in St. Albans, Queens. Malcolm X had been killed the year before and had grown larger in death than in life. Afros were in style. The Black Panthers were a force. Congas played at night on the streets.

(Pg 26-30) But there was a part of me that feared black power very deeply for the obvious reason. I thought black power would be the end of my mother. I had swallowed the white man's fear of the Negro, as we were called back then, whole. It began with a sober white newsman on our black-and-white television set introducing a news clip showing a Black Panther rally led by one of those black militant leaders, screaming to hundreds and hundreds of angry African-American students, "Black power! Black power! Black power!" while the crowd roared. I thought to myself, ***these people will kill Mommy***. Mommy, on the other hand, seemed unconcerned. Her motto was,

MOMMY: If it doesn't involve your going to school or church, I could care less about it and my answer is no whatever it is.

JAMES: She insisted on absolute privacy, excellent school grades, and trusted no outsiders of either race.

But even if she had any interest in black power, she had no time to talk about it. She worked the swing shift at Chase Manhattan Bank as a typist, leaving home at 3 p.m. and returning around 2 a.m., so she had little time for games.

On his end, my father, Andrew McBride, a Baptist minister, had his doubts about the world accepting his mixed family. He always made sure his kids never got into trouble, was concerned about money, and trusted the providence of the Holy Father to do the rest. After he died and Mommy remarried; my stepfather, Hunter Jordan, seemed to pick up where my father left off, insistent on education and church.

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On her end, Mommy had no model for raising us other than the experience of her own Orthodox Jewish family which represented the best and worst of the immigrant mentality: hard work, no nonsense, quest for excellence, and a deep belief in God and education. They believed that money without knowledge was worthless, that education tempered with religion was the way to climb out of poverty in America, and over the years they were proved right.

Yet conflict was a part of our lives. Mommy's contradictions crashed and slammed against one another like bumper cars at Coney Island. White folks, she felt, were implicitly evil toward blacks, yet she forced us to go to white schools to get the best education. Blacks could be trusted more, but anything involving blacks was probably slightly substandard. She couldn't stand racists of either color and had great distaste for bourgeois blacks who sought to emulate rich whites by putting on airs and

MOMMY: . . . doing silly things like covering their couches with plastic and holding teacups with their pinkies out. *(hissing)* What fools!

JAMES: **(Pg 32-33)** When Malcolm X talked about "the white devil" Mommy simply felt those references didn't apply to her. She viewed the civil rights achievements of black Americans with pride, as if they were her own. And she herself occasionally talked about "the white man" in the third person, as if she had nothing to do with him, and in fact she didn't, since most of her friends and social circle were black women from church.

MOMMY: What's the matter with these white folks?" *(reading the newspaper)* They're fighting over this man's money now that he's dead. None of them wanted him when he was alive, and now look at them. Forget it, honey. *(she's talking to the newspaper)* Your husband's dead, okay? He's dead – poop! You had your chance. Is money gonna bring him back? No!

JAMES: Then she'd turn to us and deliver the invariable lecture:

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MOMMY: You don't need money. What's money if your mind is empty! Educate your mind! Is this world crazy or am I the crazy one? It's probably me.

JAMES: Indeed it probably was – at least, I thought so. I knew of no other white woman who would board the subway in Manhattan at one o'clock every morning and fall asleep till she got to her stop in Queens 45 minutes later. Her lack of fear for her safety – particularly among blacks, where she often stuck out like a sore thumb and seemed an easy target for muggers – had me stumped.

As a grown man, I understand now, understand how her Christian principles and trust in God kept her going through all her life's battles, but as a boy, my faith was not that strong. Mommy once took me to Harlem. When we got off the bus, two black men came up behind us and one of them grabbed Mommy's purse. **(Pg 35)** It seemed that the only white person for miles was my own mother. **(Pg 34)** The incident confirmed my fears that Mommy was always in danger.

(Pg 45) Mommy loved God. She went to church each and every Sunday, the only white person in sight, butchering the lovely hymns with a singing voice that sounded like a cross between a cold engine trying to crank on an October morning and a whining Maytag washer. My siblings and I would muffle our laughter as Mommy dug into hymns with verve and gusto:

MOMMY: Leaning. . . .oh, leannnning . . . safe and secure on the --- *

JAMES: Up, up, and away she went, her shrill voice climbing higher and higher. **(Pg 50-51)** Even as a boy I knew God was all-powerful because of Mommy's utter deference to Him, and also because she would occasionally do something in church that I never saw her do at home or anywhere else: at some point in the service, usually when the congregation was singing one of her favorite songs, like "What a Friend We Have in Jesus," she would bow down her head and weep. It was the only time I ever saw her cry. I asked her one afternoon after service . . .

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JAMES: Why do you cry in church?

MOMMY: Because God makes me happy.

JAMES: Then why cry?

MOMMY: I'm crying 'cause I'm happy. Anything wrong with that?

JAMES: But there was [something wrong], because happy people did not seem to cry like she did. Mommy's tears seemed to come from somewhere else, a place far away, a place inside her that she never let any of us children visit, and even as a boy I felt there was pain behind them. I thought it was because she wanted to be black like everyone else in church, because maybe God liked black people better, and one afternoon on the way home from church I asked her whether God was black or white.

MOMMY: *(a deep sigh)* Oh boy. . . God's not black. He's not white. He's a spirit.

JAMES: Does he like black or white people better?

MOMMY: He loves all people. He's a spirit.

JAMES: What color is God's spirit?

MOMMY: It doesn't have a color. God is the color of water. Water doesn't have a color.

JAMES: **(Pg 274)** There are probably a hundred reasons why [Mommy] should have stayed on the Jewish side, instead of taking New Jersey Transit and the F train to go to a Christian church in Brooklyn, but I'm glad she came over to the African-American side. She married two extraordinary men and raised twelve very creative and talented children [who became doctors, professors, chemists, and teachers].

(Pg 277) Like any family we have problems, but we have always been close. Through marriage and adoptions, the original dozen has expanded into dozens and dozens more -- wives, husbands, children, grandchildren, cousins, nieces, nephews -- ranging from dark-skinned to light-skinned; from black kinky hair to

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blond hair and blue eyes. In running from her past, Mommy has created her own nation.

(Afterword to the 10th Anniversary Edition) I have met hundreds of mothers – African American, Jewish, European, Arab, Latino, African, Muslim, Christian, Hindu, Buddhist – and all of them understand that family love, a mother's love gives us grace, courage, and power beyond measure.

One afternoon, a few years ago, my African American daughter, who was about eight years old asked me:

DAUGHTER: "Daddy, if Grandma is your mother, how come she doesn't look like me or you?"

JAMES: I gave her the only answer I could: I don't know. But she loves us, and that's the most important thing.

In all the important ways, my family's story is not unique. It plays out across the world, on every continent, in every nation, city, town and village every day.

Family love: It is firm footing, something to cling to in a frightened world that seems to spin out of control with war, turmoil, terrorism and uncertainty. It is our highest calling and our greatest nobility.

So if you see a woman driving in Trenton with her blinkers on, look out. Back off. Give her some space. She could go left, she could go right. She could go up into Heaven clear out of sight! But no matter which way she goes, she's not likely going your way. And if she is, don't bother her with any questions about it, or you'll get an earful of God.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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**** This hymn is entitled Leaning on the Everlasting Arms and can be accessed at this link: https://www.youtube.com/watch?reload=9&v=Ei0ZDlF-TcE***

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